“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Madhya-līlā

Chapter 12

The Guṇḍicā Temple

(translated from the Bengali for this edition)

1 Together with His own devotees, Gaura swept and washed the temple of Śrī Guṇḍicā. He made it cool and radiant like His own heart, a fit place for Kṛṣṇa to be seated.

2 Glory, glory to Gauracandra! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaitacandra! Glory to all the devotees of Gaura![1]

3 Glory, glory to Śrīvāsa and all the devotees of Gaura! Give me strength, that I may describe Śrī Caitanya.

4 Earlier, when the Lord returned from the South, the Gajapati king grew eager to meet Him.

5 From Kaṭaka he sent a letter to Sārvabhauma: “If the Lord permits, I shall come to see Him.”

6 The Bhaṭṭācārya wrote back that the Lord had not given permission. Then the king sent him another letter:

7 “Please petition, on my behalf, all the devotees who are with the Lord.

8 May all those merciful souls be kind to me and humbly plead for me at the Lord’s feet.

9 By their grace one reaches the feet of the Lord. Without the Lord's mercy, my kingdom gives me no joy.

10 If Gaurahari will not be merciful to me, I shall give up my kingdom, become a yogī and live as a beggar."

11 Seeing the letter, the Bhaṭṭācārya grew anxious, and he took it to the devotees.

12 Meeting them all, he told them about the king, and then he showed everyone the letter.

13 Seeing the letter, everyone was amazed: "What devotion the Gajapati has for the Lord's feet!"

14 They all said, "The Lord will never meet him. And if we ask Him, He will be pained."

15 Sārvabhauma said, "Let us all go to Him once. We will not ask Him to meet the king; we will only tell Him how the king is behaving."

16 Saying this, they all went to Mahāprabhu. Everyone was eager to speak, yet no one said a word.

17 The Lord said, "What have you all come to tell Me? I see that you want to say something, yet you do not speak. Why?"

18 Nityānanda said, "We want to put something before You. We cannot keep silent, yet our hearts are afraid to speak.

19 Proper or improper, we want to tell You everything: if he cannot meet You, the king wants to become a yogī.

20 He says, ‘I will put the yogī’s rings in my ears and become a beggar. Without Gaurahari, my heart finds no joy in royal pleasures.

21 I shall gaze on that moonlike face to my eyes’ fill, and I shall lift those lotus feet and hold them to my heart.’”

22 Though the Lord’s heart softened when He heard this, outwardly He spoke harsh words:

23 “You all want to take Me to Kaṭaka and have Me meet the king.

24 Never mind spiritual welfare — people will condemn Me. And never mind the people — Dāmodara will scold Me.

25 I will not meet the king at the bidding of all of you. When Dāmodara tells Me to, then I shall meet him.”

26 Dāmodara said, “You are the independent Lord. You know everything — what should be done and what should not.

27 What tiny soul am I, to give You rules? You will meet him of Your own accord, and that too I shall see.

28 The king holds You in affection, and You are ruled by affection. His affection will win him Your touch.

29 Though You are the Lord and supremely independent, by Your very nature You are subject to love.”

30 Nityānanda said, “Who is there who would tell You, ‘Go and meet the king’?

31 But one who loves has this nature: if he cannot reach the one he longs for, he gives up his life.

32 The wives of the brāhmaṇas who performed sacrifice are proof of this: for Kṛṣṇa's sake, one of them gave up her life before her husband's eyes.

33 There is one way, if You will hear it, by which his life may be saved even though You do not meet him.

34 If You mercifully give him one of Your outer cloths, he will receive it and keep himself alive, holding on to the hope of seeing You."

35 The Lord said, "You are all very learned. Arrange whatever is best."

36 Then Nityānanda Gosāñi asked Govinda for one of the Lord's outer cloths and took it.

37 He gave the cloth to Sārvabhauma, and Sārvabhauma sent it to the king.

38 Receiving the cloth, the king rejoiced, and he worshipped it as the Lord Himself.

39 When Rāmānanda Rāya returned from the South, he asked the king to let him stay with the Lord.

40 The king gladly gave him leave, and himself began to speak of his wish to meet the Lord:

41 "Mahāprabhu is very merciful to you. You must entreat Him to meet me."

42 When the two of them came to the Kṣetra together, Rāmānanda Rāya went to meet the Lord.

43 At the Lord's feet he told of the king's loving devotion, and whenever the occasion arose he spoke of it again and again.

44 Rāmānanda, the king's minister, was skilled in dealing with people; by telling of the king's love he softened the Lord's heart.

45 Pratāparudra could no longer bear his longing, and Rāmānanda entreated the Lord to meet him.

46 Rāmānanda petitioned at the Lord's feet: "Just once, show Your feet to Pratāparudra."

47 The Lord said, "Rāmānanda, think it over and tell Me: is it fitting for a sannyāsī to meet a king?

48 If a mendicant meets a king, both his worlds are lost. Never mind the next world — even here people mock him."

49 Rāmānanda said, "You are the independent Lord. Whom need You fear? You depend on no one."

50 The Lord said, "I am a human being, a sannyāsī by āśrama. In body, mind and word I am fearful about My conduct.

51 As a spot of ink cannot be hidden on white cloth, so everyone talks of a sannyāsī's slightest fault."

52 Rāya said, "You have delivered so many sinners! And the Gajapati is a servant of the Lord and Your devotee."

53 The Lord said, "It is like a pot full of milk: if a single drop of wine falls into it, no one will touch it.

54 Although Pratāparudra has every good quality, the single name ‘king’ has stained him.

55 Still, if you are so insistent, then bring his son to meet Me.

56 Scripture says, ‘One’s self is born as one’s son.’ So when his son meets Me, it will be as if the king himself had met Me.”

57 Rāya then went and told the king everything, and at the Lord’s bidding he brought the king’s son.

58 The king’s son was beautiful and dark-complexioned, in the bloom of youth, with long lotus eyes.

59 Dressed in yellow and wearing jewelled ornaments, he awakened the remembrance of Śrī Kṛṣṇa — he was an *uddīpana*.

60 Seeing him, Mahāprabhu remembered Kṛṣṇa. Overwhelmed with love, He embraced him and began to speak:

61 “Here is a *mahā-bhāgavata*, at whose sight everyone remembers the son of the king of Vraja.

62 Seeing him, I have attained My goal.” Saying this, the Lord embraced him again.

63 At the Lord’s touch the prince was overcome with prema: he sweated and trembled, wept, became stunned, and his hair stood on end.

64 He cried “Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa!”, danced and wept. Seeing his good fortune, the devotees praised him.

65 Then Mahāprabhu calmed him and told him, “Come and see Me every day.”

66 Taking leave, Rāya came back with the prince. The king was delighted to see how his son behaved.

67 Embracing his son, he was overwhelmed with love, as if he had received Mahāprabhu’s touch directly.

68 From then on the fortunate prince was one of the Lord’s devotees.

69 In this way Mahāprabhu constantly enjoyed His pastimes with His devotees in the joy of saṅkīrtana.

70 Advaita Ācārya and other devotees would invite the Lord, and He would take His meal at each of their homes together with His devotees.

71 So, amid many joys, some days passed, and Jagannātha’s Ratha-yātrā drew near.

72 First the Lord called Kāśī Miśra; then He sent for the *paḍichā-pātra* and Sārvabhauma.

73 Smiling, the Lord spoke to the three of them and begged for the service of cleaning the Guṇḍicā temple.

74 The *paḍichā* said, “We are all Your servants. Whatever You wish is our duty.

75 Moreover, the king has specially ordered me to carry out at once whatever the Lord commands.

76 Cleaning the temple is not a service worthy of You. But if it is Your wish, it will be one of Your pastimes.

77 Many pots and brooms will be needed, though. Give the order, and I shall bring them all here today."

78 Knowing the Lord's wish, the *paḍichā* brought a hundred new pots and a hundred brooms.

79 Early the next day the Lord gathered His own devotees and with His own hand anointed them all with sandal paste.

80 With His own hand He gave each of them a broom, and the Lord Himself set out, taking them all with Him.

81 He went to the Guṇḍicā temple to clean it. First they took the brooms and swept it clean.

82 He scrubbed everything inside the temple, even the ceiling; He cleaned the throne and set it back in its place.

83 He swept and cleaned the small and large shrines, and afterwards cleaned the Śrī Jagamohana in the same way.

84 On every side a hundred devotees were sweeping. The Lord Himself cleaned and taught them all.

85 Joyful with love, He cleaned and chanted Kṛṣṇa's name; the devotees, too, chanted "Kṛṣṇa!" as they did their work.

86 His body, grey with dust, was beautiful to see. In places He washed the floor with the water of His tears.

87 After cleaning the *bhoga-mandira* He cleaned the courtyard, and then, one after another, all the rooms.

88 He gathered straw, dust and grit into one heap, took it up in His outer cloth and carried it outside to throw it away.

89 In the same way the devotees gathered straw and dust in their own cloths and threw it outside with great joy.

90 The Lord said, “Who has swept how much? Just by seeing your straw and dust I shall know how hard you have worked.”

91 All the heaps of sweepings were put together, and the Lord’s heap was larger than everyone else’s.

92 When the inside had been cleaned in this way, He again divided the work among them all:

93 “Remove all the fine dust, straw and pebbles. Clean the Lord’s inner chamber thoroughly.”

94 When He and all the Vaiṣṇavas had cleaned it twice, Mahāprabhu was satisfied to see it.

95 Another hundred people had filled a hundred pots with water and stood holding them from the start, waiting for the moment.

96 When Mahāprabhu called out, “Bring water!”, they brought the hundred pots and set them before the Lord.

97 First the Lord washed the temple: the walls from top to bottom, the inside of the room and the throne.

98 Filling clay bowls with water, He threw it up high; with that water He cleaned the ceiling and washed the walls.

99 With His own hand He cleaned the throne, while the devotees brought water and set it before Him.

100 The devotees washed the inside of the room, each cleaning the temple with his own hands.

101 Some brought water and poured it into Mahāprabhu's hands; some poured water over His feet.

102 Some secretly drank that water; some begged for it, and some gave it to others.

103 When the rooms had been washed, they let the water out through the drain, and it flooded the whole courtyard.

104 With His own cloth the Lord wiped the room, and with His own cloth Mahāprabhu polished the throne.

105 With the water of a hundred pots the temple was cleaned. Purifying the temple, He made it like His own mind.

106 He made the temple spotless, cool and soothing, as if He had brought His own heart outside.

107 Hundreds upon hundreds of people drew water from the lake. There was no room left at the bathing *ghāṭa*, so some drew water from a well.

108 A hundred devotees came carrying full pots, and another hundred went off with the empty ones.

109 Except for Nityānanda, Advaita, Svarūpa, Bhāratī and Purī, everyone filled pots and brought water.

110 Many pots broke as they knocked against one another, and people brought hundreds more.

111 They filled pots, washed the rooms and called out the name of Hari. Apart from the sounds “Kṛṣṇa!” and “Hari!”, nothing else could be heard.

112 Saying “Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa!” some asked for a water pot, and saying “Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa!” others handed one over.

113 Whoever had something to say said only the name of Kṛṣṇa: Kṛṣṇa’s name became the signal for every task.

114 Absorbed in love, the Lord chanted the name “Kṛṣṇa, Kṛṣṇa,” and in that absorption He alone did the work of a hundred men.

115 It was as if He were washing and cleaning with a hundred hands. Going up to each person, He showed him how to do the work.

116 When He saw good work, He praised the worker; when the work did not satisfy Him, He gave a rebuke — but a pure, purifying one.

117 “You have done well. Now teach the others, so that they too do such good work.”

118 Hearing these words, everyone felt abashed, and all of them set about the work properly, with full attention.

119 Then they washed the Śrī Jagamohana, and after that the *bhoga-mandira* and the other halls.

120 After washing the Nāṭaśālā, they washed the courtyards, and then the kitchen and all the other rooms.

121 They washed the temple on all four sides and thoroughly washed all the inner rooms.

122 At that moment a simple and sensible Gauḍīyā (devotee from Bengal) poured water from his pot over the Lord's feet.

123 Then he took that water and drank it himself. Seeing this, Mahāprabhu became angry.

124 Although the Lord was pleased with him, to uphold proper conduct (*dharma*) He showed great anger outwardly.

125 To teach everyone, He called Svarūpa and said to him, "Just look at how your 'Gauḍīyā' behaves!

126 He washed My feet in the temple of the Lord, and then took that water and drank it himself.

127 What will become of Me for this offense? Your 'Gauḍīyā' has brought such misfortune upon Me!"

128 Then Svarūpa Gosāñi took him by the neck, gave him a shove, and put him outside the temple compound.

129 Coming back, he humbly pleaded at the Lord's feet: "It is fitting to forgive the offense of an ignorant man."

130 Then Mahāprabhu was satisfied, and He seated everyone in rows on two sides.

131 Sitting between them, He began to pick up straw, grit and rubbish with His own hand.

132 “I shall gather together all that is collected and see who has picked up how much. Whoever has the least will have to pay Me in cakes and sweet drinks.”

133 In this way He cleansed the whole temple and made it cool and spotless, like His own heart.

134 When the water was let out through the drain, it looked like a new river rushing to meet the sea.

135 In the same way they cleansed all the roads in front of the temple gate. Who could describe how much was cleansed?

136 He cleansed the temple of Nṛsiṁha inside and out, and after resting for a moment He began to dance.

137 On all sides the devotees sang *kīrtana*, and in the middle the Lord danced like a maddened lion.

138 Perspiration, trembling, pallor, tears, thrills of rapture and loud roars appeared in Him. Streams of tears washed His body and ran on ahead of Him.

139 On every side they washed the devotees’ bodies, like a cloud pouring rain in the month of Śrāvaṇa.

140 The sky was filled with the very loud *saṅkīrtana*, and the earth quaked under the Lord’s high-leaping dance.

141 Svarūpa's loud singing always delighted the Lord, and Gaurarāya danced in bliss, leaping high.

142 After dancing like this for some time, the Lord, aware of the hour, stopped to rest.

143 Ācārya Gosāñi had a son named Śrī Gopāla, and the Lord, Gauradhāma, ordered him to dance.

144 Dancing in the absorption of love, he fainted and fell unconscious to the ground.

145 The Ācārya hastily took him on his lap, and seeing that he was not breathing, he became distraught.

146 Reciting the *mantra* of Nṛsiṁha, he sprinkled him with water, and at the sound of his roar the universe seemed to burst apart.

147 He tried many things, yet the boy did not regain consciousness. The Ācārya wept, and all the devotees wept with him.

148 Then Mahāprabhu placed His hand on the boy's chest and called out loudly, "Rise up, Gopāla!"

149 As soon as he heard this, Gopāla regained consciousness, and all the devotees danced, calling out "Hari!"

150 Vṛndāvana dāsa has described this pastime, and so I have told it only briefly.

151 Then, after resting a little, Mahāprabhu went with the devotees to bathe.

152 Coming up onto the bank, the Lord put on dry cloth, bowed down to Nṛsiṁhadeva, and went into the garden.

153 The Lord sat down in the garden with the devotees, and then Vāṇīnātha arrived with *mahā-prasāda*.

154 Kāśī Miśra and Tulasī, the temple superintendent (*paḍichā*), had sent as much food as five hundred people could eat:

155 all that rice, all those cakes and sweet drinks. Seeing it, Mahāprabhu was very pleased.

156 Purī Gosāñi, Mahāprabhu, Brahmānanda Bhāratī, Advaita Ācārya and Nityānanda Prabhu;

157 Ācāryaratna, Ācāryanidhi, Śrīvāsa, Gadādhara, Śaṅkara, Nandanācārya, Rāghava and Vakreśvara —

158 at the Lord's bidding Sārvabhauma, too, sat down; and the Lord sat on a raised wooden seat (*piṇḍā*) together with these devotees.

159 Below them, row after row, the devotees sat down to eat, filling the whole garden.

160 The Lord called again and again, "Haridāsa!" But Haridāsa stayed at a distance and humbly submitted:

161 "Let the Lord take *prasāda* with the devotees. Worthless as I am, I am not fit to sit in this company.

162 Later Govinda will give me *prasāda* outside the gate." Knowing his mind, the Lord did not call him again.

163–164 Svarūpa Gosāñi, Jagadānanda, Dāmodara, Kāśīśvara, Gopīnātha, Vāṇīnātha and Śaṅkara — these seven served the food there, while from time to time the devotees called out “Hari!”

165 Mahāprabhu remembered the pastime of long ago when Kṛṣṇa ate with His friends on the riverbank (*pulina-bhojana*).

166 Though the absorption of love shook the Lord, He understood the occasion and composed Himself somewhat.

167 The Lord said, “Give Me the *lāphrā*, the plain mixed vegetables, and give the devotees the cakes, sweet drinks and *amṛta-guṭikā*.”

168 The all-knowing Lord knew what each person liked, and through Svarūpa He had each one served just that.

169 Jagadānanda went about serving, and now and then he would unexpectedly put some choice item on the Lord’s plate.

170 Though the Lord grew angry with him for it, Jagadānanda still gave Him such things, by force or by trick, and only when he had given them was he satisfied.

171 Then he would keep his eye on that food, and out of fear of him the Lord would eat a little.

172 If He did not eat, Jagadānanda would fast. With this fear in His mind, the Lord would eat a little in front of him.

173 Svarūpa Gosāñi would take some choice sweet *prasāda*, stand before the Lord and offer it to Him:

174 “Taste a little of this *mahā-prasāda*. See how Jagannātha has eaten of it!”

175 Saying this, he would set a little before Him, and out of affection for him the Lord would eat some.

176 The two of them did this again and again. Wonderful were the loving dealings of these two devotees!

177 The Lord had seated Sārvabhauma at His left side, and seeing the affection of the two devotees, Sārvabhauma smiled.

178 The Lord had the best *prasāda* served to Sārvabhauma, and out of affection He made him eat again and again.

179 Gopīnātha Ācārya brought excellent *mahā-prasāda*, gave it to Sārvabhauma, and spoke very sweet words:

180 “Just consider: where were the Bhaṭṭācārya’s former worldly dealings, and where is this supreme bliss now!”

181 Sārvabhauma said, “I was a logician of crooked intellect. It is by your grace that I have gained this wealth.

182 No one is as merciful as Mahāprabhu. He turns a crow into a Garuḍa — who else is like that?

183 I used to howl with the jackals of logic, and now with that same mouth I always say ‘Kṛṣṇa!’ and ‘Hari!’

184 Where was I then, in the company of disciples who were logicians averse to the Lord, and where am I now, in the waves of this ocean of nectarean company!”

185 The Lord said, “Your love for Kṛṣṇa was already perfected before. In your company all of us have turned our minds to Kṛṣṇa.”

186 In all the three worlds there is no one but Mahāprabhu who so increases the glory of His devotees and gives them such happiness.

187 Then the Lord, calling each devotee by name, had cakes and sweet drinks given to all as His *prasāda*.

188 Advaita and Nityānanda were sitting together, and right there a playful quarrel broke out between the two of them.

189 Advaita said, “I have eaten in the same row as an *avadhūta*! I do not know what will become of me.

190 The Lord is a *sannyāsī*: He loses nothing by it. Faults in food bring no fault to a *sannyāsī*.

191 ‘An ascetic is not tainted by faults in food’ — this is the evidence of scripture. But I am a householder *brāhmaṇa*: for me it is a cause of fault.

192 To eat in the same row with someone whose birth, family, character and conduct are unknown is a great impropriety.”

193 Nityānanda replied, “You are Advaita Ācārya — the teacher of non-duality! The ‘doctrine of non-duality’ obstructs the practice of pure devotion.

194 Whoever keeps company with Your doctrine accepts nothing ‘second’ besides the ‘one’ reality.

195 And here I am eating together with such a person as You! I do not know what will happen to My mind in Your company.”

196 In this way the two of them bandied words: each praised the other in the guise of abuse.

197 Then the Lord, calling out the names of all the Vaiṣṇavas, gave out *mahā-prasāda*, as if sprinkling them with the greatest nectar.

198 When they had eaten, everyone rose, calling out “Hari!” and the sound of “Hari” rose up and filled heaven and earth.

199 Then, with His own hand, Mahāprabhu gave garlands and sandal paste to all His devotees.

200 Then the servers, the seven headed by Svarūpa, ate *prasāda* inside the house.

201 Govinda had kept aside the Lord’s remnants, and he took some of that food and gave it to Haridāsa.

202 The devotees begged a little of it from Govinda, and what remained of that *prasāda* Govinda took himself.

203 The Lord is the independent Supreme Lord and plays many kinds of games. This one pastime He called “washing and scrubbing” (*dhoyā-pākhalā*).

204 The next day came Jagannātha’s great festival called Netrotsava, as dear to the devotees as life itself.

205 For a fortnight the people had grieved at not seeing the Lord; now, seeing Him again, they rejoiced at heart.

206 Happily Mahāprabhu took all the devotees and went to see Jagannātha.

207 Kāśīśvara went in front, holding back the crowd, and behind came Govinda, carrying a water pot.

208 In front of the Lord walked Purī and Bhāratī, and beside the two of them walked Svarūpa and Advaita.

209 The other devotees walked behind, and all of them went eagerly to Jagannātha's temple.

210 In their longing to see Him they set aside the rules, went into the *bhoga-maṇḍapa*, and gazed on His beautiful face.

211 The Lord's thirsty eyes, like a pair of bees, drank with deep thirst from the lotus of Kṛṣṇa's face.

212 His eyes surpassed full-blown lotuses, and His cheeks glistened with the luster of a sapphire mirror.

213 His bright red lips surpassed the *bāndhulī* flower, and the radiance of His gentle smile was a wave of nectar.

214 Moment by moment the lovely luster of His beautiful face grew, and the bee-like eyes of millions of devotees drank its honey.

215 The more they drank, the more their thirst grew without end; the eyes would not leave that lotus face to go elsewhere.

216 In this way Mahāprabhu and the devotees gazed on His beautiful face until midday.

217 Perspiration, trembling and tears flowed from Him all the while, but in His longing to see, the Lord held them back.

218 From time to time food was offered, and in between there was *darśana*; during the offerings the Lord performed *kīrtana*.

219 In the bliss of seeing Him, the Lord forgot everything, and at midday the devotees took Him away.

220 Knowing that the Ratha-yātrā would take place the next morning, the servants offered twice as much food.

221 I have briefly told of the cleansing of the Guṇḍicā temple. By seeing it and hearing of it, even sinners attained devotion to Kṛṣṇa.

222 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.

Notes

1. The same verse as Madhya 4.2 (the refrain of Ādi 4.2 with *gauracandra* in the first line); translation as there. ↩